Let’s remember: the ideological and political father of Revisionist Zionism, Ze’ev Jabotinsky, pleaded for including “both sides of the Jordan” within his dreamed-for Jewish State. His successors became rather more modest and demanded Eretz Israel, that is, the whole of Palestine between the Jordan River and the Mediterranean Sea (as, on the morrow of World War I, the British government had separated Palestine from Trans-Jordan). All of these expectations remained rather theoretical, as between 1919 and May 1948 Palestine was turned into a British mandate by the League of Nations. After they had given contradictory secret assurances to both the Jews and the Arabs, and after promising a homeland to the Jews in Palestine in 1917 (the Balfour Declaration), the British became successively favorable to Jewish or Arab interests according to their immediate political aims.

Every colonial power was duplicitous in its day, but it seems to me that, in the Middle East in particular, British duplicity reached an apex. And, for good measure, the Colonial Office added a huge portion of antisemitism.

In November 1947, two years after the end of World War II and the Holocaust, and after a series of commissions of inquiry and vociferous debates, the United Nations voted the partition of Palestine between a Jewish state and a Palestinian state. The United States and the Soviet Union supported the decision; it was opposed by the Palestinians and the Arab states. I remember attending a huge celebration of the event at the Vel d’Hiv, the same cavernous hall in which the Jews of Paris had been held, in July 1942, before being sent to transit camps for deportation. The platform for dignitaries was so overcrowded that it crashed; some were injured. A bad omen.

The Palestinians launched an increasingly fierce guerrilla war against the Jewish population of the country; it turned into a generalized war involving Palestinian militias and the armies of the neighboring Arab states, plus Iraq, after the Israeli declaration of independence in May 1948. By 1949, Israel